impossible for us both to continue with our respective careers and that one of us needed to be at home to take charge of the house and family. To my relief, Anjali took over the home front, allowing me to continue with my cricket, and I will always appreciate the sacrifice she made very early in our lives.

The wedding was a traditional affair and, as in most conventional Maharashtrian households, my mother gave Anjali the mangalsutra (a necklace worn by the wife to ensure her husband's good health), sindoor (vermilion, the red powder worn as an auspicious mark by Indian married women), green bangles, anklets and a toe ring, which are all considered part of the wedding ritual. In fact, I remember her asking me if I wanted her to wear all or any of the things that my mother had given her. All I said was I wanted her to wear the mangalsutra, and to this day she has never taken it off.

These adjustments, both in her professional and personal life, could not have been easy but she has never shown any resentment. This has not only added to my respect for Anjali but also meant I had actually found someone who I could love and depend on. I must confess it is not always in my nature to say what I feel, but there is no doubt how much I owe her. Funnily enough, I have never called her by her name. I haven't ever said 'Anjali' or 'Anja' or any such thing while calling her. In all these years I have not been able to figure out how I should refer to her. Frankly, it doesn't really matter, for that is how I am and, despite all my shortcomings, my wife has been with me every step of the way.

At the beginning, marriage did have one unfortunate side-effect, however. Marital bliss led me to relax my routine and the outcome was weight gain. I enjoyed myself thoroughly during our honeymoon and indulged my palate to a nicety. We had a few of our friends with us in Goa, where I was also playing a double-wicket tournament, and that added to the fun. Almost every day during the honeymoon I feasted on deliciously decadent desserts and other delicacies I normally kept away from during the playing season. There were plenty of chocolates and ice creams and such indulgence came at a price.

When I returned to Mumbai I realized that I couldn't get into any of my clothes. I had put on a few inches around the waist and it was time for some strict control on the culinary front. We weren't playing a great deal of cricket in 1995 and that was another reason why I had let down my guard. So for twenty straight days after returning to Mumbai, I put